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# THE WAIL OF BUGLES

The retreat from Kabul began soon after 9 a.m. on the morning of 6 January 1842.

The night before, the now almost recovered Lieutenant Sturt had mined a portion of the walls to the left of the rear gate so as to create a wide breach through which the 3,800 remaining sepoys, 700 European cavalry and footsoldiers and 14,000 camp followers could march. At dawn the mine was sprung, and the walls blown outwards so as to create a bridge over the ditch.

Seen through the jagged new gap in the curtain wall, the sun rising over the ring of dazzling white mountains around Kabul revealed a day that was 'beautifully clear and frosty, with the snow nearly a foot deep on the ground'.[1] Yet the troops waiting to march out of the relative safety of the cantonment walls to an uncertain fate in the Afghan mountains were a less inspiring sight. 'A crouching, drooping, dispirited army, so different from the smart light-hearted body of men they appeared some time ago,' thought a depressed George Lawrence, who had been released, along with Colin Mackenzie, to help supervise the retreat. On marching out into the virgin snow 'the men were [soon] sinking a foot deep each step . . . My heart sunk within me under the conviction that we were a doomed force.'[2]

A fortnight had now passed since the British had heard for sure that their political leader, Sir William Hay Macnaghten, had been murdered by Akbar Khan. After two days of anxious waiting amid contradictory rumours, the